single non-Sikh among them. Everyone stood still and silent. Suri introduced himself to two family members as a reporter from the *Indian Express* . Within a couple of minutes, he was ushered into the house and offered a seat on the only piece of furniture (a charpoy) in the room.

He told the two family members the reason for his coming to Rode. Suri describes what followed:

> (one of the men) ... came carrying a thali with food – roti, daal, pickle and vegetables ... The kind host, because that was what this man had become, asked me if I had eaten anything through the day. I said I hadn't. He probably figured I was more in need of food than information, and in any case, he had no information to give ... Nothing remotely like an armed rebellion had erupted ...
>
> I was an alien Hindu when suspicions around alien Hindus in Punjab could have been at the peak. But I was offered rest, care and a meal ... Bhindranwale's family did not forget the age-old traditions of Punjab of welcoming a stranger, looking after him, making him feel at home ... I found a better Punjab than the headlines in the newspapers I worked for had led me to expect ... My gut told me, even if not all of my brain, that if this is how I could be welcomed at Bhindranwale's house that day, Punjab would be all right. [29]

Incidentally, within a week of Operation Blue Star, I had visited my own village and a couple of other adjoining villages located at the other end of Punjab, bordering Sirsa in Haryana. I met a number of Sikhs and Hindus during that visit. In my view, Suri's description most accurately describes the prevailing mood of the Sikhs in the rural areas of Punjab, at a time when the national and local press were busy maligning many of them as extremists who nursed anti-national feelings.

Costs and Responsibility